by Muslim or British invaders. It may upset the social fabric." But why? Why must one trauma be remembered, and the other buried?

This selective amnesia breeds resentment. If truth and reconciliation is healing caste wounds to a commendable extent, why can't the same principle be applied to historical wounds left by foreign conquest?

Let us be clear: this is not about blaming today's Muslims or Christians. Just as no reasonable Dalit child today blames an upper-caste child personally for historical injustice. We must not identify today's communities with past atrocities. But we must remember the past honestly—because memory is the foundation of wisdom.

And if we are to celebrate, let us celebrate our heroes—not our oppressors. The canopy at India Gate in Delhi once housed the statue of the colonial emperor King George V. Today, it houses the statue of Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose. The symbolism is clear: we must honour those who fought for us, not those who oppressed us. Shouldn't we extend this logic across India?

Let us celebrate Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj, the lion who stood tall against Timurid-Mughal imperial tyranny. Let us honour the valiant Sikh gurus who resisted forced conversions. Let us teach our children about the Ahom generals of Assam, the Jat warriors, the Naga babas and many others who defended our culture from Aurangzeb's attacks.

NO CULTURE WITH ANY SENSE OF SELF-RESPECT OR A DESIRE TO SURVIVE GLORIFIES ITS HISTORICAL OPPRESSORS

Even within the Timurid-Mughal dynasty, there were men of wisdom and compassion. Dara Shikoh—Aurangzeb's elder brother—sought to bridge Hinduism and Islam. He translated many of the Upanishads to Persian, and authored *Majma-ul-Bahrain*, a book that sought the confluence of the two faiths. He imagined an India united in spirit, diverse in form. And what was his fate? Tortured, mutilated and executed by Aurangzeb, who sent his head in a box to their father, Emperor Shah Jahan.

Should we memorialise Aurangzeb or Dara Shikoh? The answer is clear. One symbolises tyranny and bigotry. The other, inclusivity and wisdom. Aurangzeb's ideology is celebrated in Pakistan. Perhaps we should respectfully send his bones to them. In its place, let us build a memorial to Dara Shikoh, as a symbol of true Ganga-Jamuni tehzeeb, one that reflects mutual respect, not erasure. India is a civilisational state, not just a nation-state. Civilisations do not forget. And they do not foolishly honour their tormentors. It is time we choose our civilisational heroes wisely. ■

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WHY ARE WE DIGGING GRAVES OF THE PAST?



PURUSHOTTAM AGRAWAL

The demand to dismantle the grave of Aurangzeb is only the latest in a drama series of which some episodes have been aired while others are in the pipeline. The series is the project of political Hindutva which has been unfolding vigorously for some time, and Aurangzeb is one of the most important figures in this narrative. Seen objectively in a historical perspective, Aurangzeb was ruthlessly consistent in the pursuit of power and more cruel than the average medieval king. He was also very suspicious, even intolerant of artistic expressions of human creativity. But the fact remains that he presided over the centralised administration of an Indian empire of unprecedented vastness and with a robust economy. And he did it with the active support of the Hindu elites—feudal lords, merchants and intellectuals. He also could not hold it together due to the sheer burden of its size and, perhaps more importantly, due to not paying enough attention to Akbar's model of *sulah-e-kul* (tolerance and dialogue)—as pointed out by Shivaji in a famous letter.

Obviously, present-day political Hindutva would reject even Shivaji here. How can one praise Akbar and his policies? After all, he was also a Mughal, a Muslim hence an alien to the Hindu *rashtra*. The question, 'Who says Akbar was great?', is not merely the title of a tract by Hindutva 'historian' P.N. Oak, but has also been part of the general Hindutva rhetoric. Just nine years ago, some of the BJP's top leaders wanted Akbar Road in Delhi to be renamed.

Be it the Gyanvapi mosque in Varanasi, a road in Lutyens' Delhi, a masjid in Sambhal or the grave in Sambhajinagar, the imagination of our future is also at stake here, not merely the facts of the past. In both its avatars—recorded history and popular memory—the past is sought to be converted into raw material for manufacturing consent on the Hindutva project. The